

HASHKAMA WEEKLY

פרשת שלח
כז' סיון תשפ"ו
JUNE 12, 2026
VOL 5786 ISSUE 37



By Reb Gemini חכמה ב-אI תאמין?

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini:
Did the AI get it right? Do you find

it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Ah gutten Shabbos. If you are reading this during Chazaras HaShatz, I will generously pretend not to notice, provided you at least nod thoughtfully every few minutes so the Gabbai thinks you are reviewing a complex Rashba. In Parshas Shelach, after the well-known debacle of the Meraglim, the Torah abruptly introduces us to the Mekoshesh Etzim. Here is a man who decides the absolute best time to arrange a timber collection is right in the middle of Shabbos (Bamidbar 15:32). Naturally, the Bnei Yisroel detain him, and the consequences are famously severe. Yet, the Gemara (Bava Basra 119b) reveals a fascinating, albeit perplexing, kavana behind his actions. According to this Midrash, the Mekoshesh was acting leshem Shamayim. After the decree that the generation would die in the Midbar, the Bnei Yisroel incorrectly assumed the Mitzvos no longer applied. The Mekoshesh deliberately committed a catastrophic aveirah to prove the Halacha remained very much in force. It is the extreme of taking one for the team, though I strongly advise against using this defense if the Rav catches you talking during Krias HaTorah. He essentially decided to become a cautionary tale so absolutely everyone else would stay in line.

Immediately following this bizarre incident, the Parshah transitions directly into the Mitzvah of Tzitzis (Bamidbar 15:37-41). On the surface, shifting from a tragic execution for desecrating Shabbos to tying knots on a beged seems like terrible editorial flow. However, the Daas Zekenim (Bamidbar 15:32) brilliantly connects these two distinct Inyanim. The Meforshim explain that the Mekoshesh only stumbled because it was Shabbos. During the week, a Yid wears Tefillin, which serves as a constant, physical reminder of the Ribono Shel Olam. On Shabbos, we obviously do not wear Tefillin, which abruptly left the Mekoshesh without his tangible spiritual anchor, causing his judgment to profoundly lapse. In direct response to this vulnerability, Hashem provided the Mitzvah of Tzitzis. We are given a strict chiyuv to affix Tzitzis to our garments, creating a visual cue that remains with us on Shabbos just as it does during the Chol. We look at these strings, remember the Taryag Mitzvos (Rashi, Bamidbar 15:39), and ideally avoid suddenly deciding to gather firewood. It is a profoundly elegant solution: when our internal focus inevitably falters, a few well-placed strings are there to reel us back into reality.

The **practical takeaway** here is remarkably straightforward, even if you lack the extensive Gemara background of a true Gadol. We all periodically suffer from spiritual amnesia, conveniently forgetting the strict Halacha the exact second it interferes with a phenomenal piece of juicy Lashon Hara at the weekly congregational Kiddush. We cannot ever rely entirely on our flawed intellect or supposedly pure kavanos to consistently keep us firmly on the straight and narrow Derech. As the Mekoshesh famously demonstrated, our perceived brilliance can unfortunately rationalize almost any terrible aveirah. We desperately need constant, highly tangible reminders embedded within our regular daily routine to adequately keep our chaotic lives spiritually grounded. Whether it involves routinely checking your Tzitzis, setting a rigidly fixed time for Seder, or simply opening the Shulchan Aruch before finalizing a questionable financial decision, we absolutely must proactively build robust physical guardrails. Spiritual intentions alone will not endure mundane earthly temptations. So, wrap your Tzitzis tightly around your finger, focus closely on the Davening, and please gracefully leave the firewood completely alone until Motzaei Shabbos. Gut Shabbos.

News & Simchos!

Fancy Kiddush
Sponsored By
The Garfinkel Family

Attention

Our Summer Pause is Approaching
Unless a new location is found before or during the summer vacation months

Exciting Opportunity!

Want to sponsor a נר למאור or kiddush?
We cannot promise Olam Haba, but we can absolutely guarantee vastly superior herring. Please Contact Tzvi Zev Rubin:

845-252-1260



Drasha Duty!

Convinced your chakira can outcompete the cholent for attention?

To deliver the Short Shiur during Kiddush,
Please Contact Rabbi Genack:

646-413-5551



Sponsorship

נר למאור חודש סיון
Sponsored by

Thou Shall Not Be Named

In honor of Tzvi Zev Rubin
Who fixed our internet!



Shabbus Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
6:55/8:11 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
--:-- pm	מנחה - קבלת שבת
8:29 pm	שקיעה
3:33/4:11 am	עלות השחר (16.1/72)
5:23 am	נץ החמה
7:15 am	שחרית
Hot kiddush & Shiur after davening	
8:34/9:10 am	סיור קריאת שמע
10:01/10:25 am	סיור תפילה
12:56 pm	חצות היום
1:34 pm	מנחה גדולה (גר"א)
5:21 pm	מנחה קטנה (גר"א)
6:55 pm	פלג המנחה (גר"א)
--:-- pm	מנחה
8:30 pm	שקיעה
9:21/9:20 pm	צה"כ ר' משה (8.5/50)
9:22 pm	מעריב (52)
9:30/9:42 pm	צה"כ (60/72)



Next Week's Zmanim

Chestnut Ridge, NY

2:30 pm	מנחה
6:57/8:14 pm	הדלקה (Early/Late)
8:32 pm	שקיעה
7:15 am	שחרית
8:32 pm	שקיעה
9:24 pm	מעריב (52)

Parshah-ly Punny!

Riddle: Why did the ten Meraglim haul such a massive cluster of grapes all the way back to the camp?

Answer: They figured if the entire congregation was going to cry all night, they might as well do some heavy wine-ing.



Donations & Payments

Zelle: Send to 845-252-1260

Check: Write Out to Bais Midrash 715

Cash: Hand to Tzvi Zev or Adam Edelstein

Credit Card: Visit the link cc.bm715.vip

Gift Card/Bitcoin: Do we look like Indian Scammers to you?

משל ונמשל ב-Al תאמין?

By Reb Gemini

Consider the following "Torah" thought, generated by Gemini: Did the AI get it right? Do you find it to be accurate? Or did the technology miss the boat?

Mashal: Let us consider a classic Mashal involving a phenomenally wealthy Gevir who generously funds the construction of a state-of-the-art Mikvah in the center of town. Recognizing he knows nothing about zoning laws, the Gevir hires a brilliant, highly analytical Kollel yungerman as his exclusive project manager. The yungerman receives rigid instructions: inspect the property, determine the optimal placement for the boros, find the best local contractors, and return with an architectural plan. The Gevir hands him a blank check and explicitly says, "Go figure out how we build this." Two weeks later, the yungerman returns to the Gevir's luxurious office and delivers his report. He explains that he researched soil density, interviewed the municipal planning board, and analyzed the steep costs of premium copper plumbing. Based on his rigorous calculus, the yungerman concludes the project is a terrible investment. The ground is too rocky, the bureaucrats are exceptionally difficult to bribe, and honestly, the community would be better served if the Gevir just sponsored an endless supply of cholent for Thursday night Mishmar. The Gevir immediately fires the yungerman. The yungerman is bewildered, defensively arguing his meticulous research is perfectly accurate. The Gevir sternly replies, "I never asked you to decide if we should build the Mikvah. I have the money, and I already decided we are building it. I only asked you to figure out how to get the dirt out of the ground."

Nimshal: This tragic misunderstanding is precisely the Nimshal for the catastrophic failure of the Meraglim in Parshas Shelach. When Moshe Rabbeinu sent these twelve illustrious Nesiim to scout Eretz Yisroel, he gave them incredibly specific tactical directives (Bamidbar 13:17-20). As the Ramban (Bamidbar 13:2) masterfully explains, their sole mandate was purely logistical. They were supposed to figure out which roads were most accessible and what local defenses the Bnei Yisroel would encounter upon their inevitable arrival. Hashem had already firmly promised them the land; the strategic victory was a completely guaranteed reality. The Meraglim, however, were unfortunately too brilliant for their own good. As the Malbim (Bamidbar 13:31) astutely observes, they subtly shifted their official role from objective scouts to executive policymakers. They looked at the massive Nefilim and heavily fortified Canaanite cities (Bamidbar 13:28) and ran their own independent risk assessment. They concluded the physical obstacles were insurmountable, tragically declaring, "Ki chazak hu mimenu" (Bamidbar 13:31). The Gemara (Sotah 35a) notes the terrifying audacity of this statement, suggesting they essentially claimed that even the Ribono Shel Olam could not overcome these giants. Like the overly analytical yungerman, they fundamentally forgot that the ultimate decision-maker had already issued the final ruling. They were not sent to evaluate if the conquest was possible; they were sent to scout the practical mechanics of a miracle Hashem was unconditionally funding.

Practical Takeaway: The exceptionally practical takeaway is that we constantly suffer from this exact same catastrophic overthinking in our daily Avodas Hashem. We are all incredibly proficient at running uninvited cost-benefit analyses on the Ribono Shel Olam's explicit commandments. When confronted with a challenging Mitzvah, a difficult Shidduch suggestion, or the overwhelming prospect of paying exorbitant Yeshiva tuition, we immediately transform into amateur actuaries. We frantically calculate our limited resources, analyze the intimidating societal Nefilim in our way, and logically conclude the spiritual project is not viable. Our deeply ingrained Litvish tendency to over-analyze a Sugya is phenomenal when sitting in the Beis Medrash trying to understand a complicated Ketzos, but it is an absolute disaster when applied to the fundamental requirement of Emunah and Bitachon. The Chovos HaLevavos (Shaar HaBitachon, Chapter 3) reminds us that our strictly limited job is merely to put in the requisite Hishtadlus, not to successfully manage the entire cosmic outcome. When Hashem commands us to move forward, our only acceptable calculation is figuring out the immediate next logistical step, not questioning the structural integrity of the Divine plan. So, the next time you find yourself staring at an impossible budget or a terrifyingly complex challenge, politely resign from your self-appointed position as Hashem's Chief Risk Officer. Let the Ribono Shel Olam worry about the heavy lifting, keep your head down, and just figure out how to dig the next hole. Ah gutten Shabbos.

GOOD SHABBUS!